

The greatest medical practitioner of his era, Claudius Galenus, better known as Galen, was physician to three Roman emperors, a skilled surgeon and anatomist, and a prolific author. His work took Greco-Roman medical knowledge to its highest level, and his ideas prevailed until the Renaissance, 1,300 years after his death.

MILESTONES

FIGHTERS' DOCTOR

Appointed physician to the gladiators by the high priest of the temple of Pergamon in 159 CE.

PLAGUE IN ROME

Treats the victims of the Antonine plague, thought to be smallpox, which breaks out in 166 CE.

LEAVES THE CAPITAL

Stays away from Rome from 166 CE to 169 CE due to his unpopularity with the established physicians.

STATE APPOINTMENT

Spends four decades as physician to emperors, beginning with Marcus Aurelius in 169 CE.

PROLIFIC WRITER

Writes more than 500 works, dictating to scribes. Around 100 survive a fire in his storerooms in 191 CE.

Galen was born in the eastern part of the Roman Empire, in Pergamon on the Aegean coast, which is now the Turkish city of Bergama. His father, Aelius Nicon, was a wealthy Greek architect who wanted his son to pursue a career in politics. However, it is said that when Galen was 16, the Greek god of healing, Asclepius, came to his father in a dream requesting that Galen study medicine, and he duly began his medical training at the healing temple (Asclepeion) in Pergamon.

Three years later, Galen's father died, and he used his inheritance to travel. He spent 5 years studying in Alexandria, Egypt, at the most advanced medical school in the Roman Empire. On his return to Pergamon, he worked as physician to the Roman gladiators. Galen wrote that the gladiators' wounds were as "windows into the body." Since 150 CE, Roman law had forbidden the dissection of human corpses, so these injuries gave him valuable practical insights into anatomy.

Imperial physician

In 162 CE, Galen went to the city of Rome, where he gave lectures and demonstrated his knowledge and surgical dexterity by dissecting pigs and apes. He also treated a number of eminent statesmen and caught

Galen's medical skills were well used in his role as physician to the gladiators. Only five gladiators died in his care, compared to 60 in his predecessor's time.

